

Meeting talking points

Rowan · Round 3 · Founding AI Product Engineer

Reactivation Desk — judgment, product, demo, questions

1. What Rowan is (context)

Rowan is building systems that **carry consequential work across the finish line** for financial-services firms — a firm-safe relationship execution layer, not another AI answer box.

Themes they named: missed follow-through, meaningful changes across clients/prospects, safe handoffs, correct forms/records, compliant growth opportunities, and **keeping the advisor in control**.

Round 3 does **not** prescribe the first product. Discovery evidence → decide the wedge → ship something monetizable now → defend the judgment.

2. Decision in one breath

I wasn’t picking the coolest AI idea. I was picking the first thing that can **sell now**.

Five things have to line up:

- 1. **Pain** — felt every week
- 2. **Buyer** — same person can say yes
- 3. **Price** — no committee
- 4. **Workflow** — input → decision → action → result
- 5. **Pay now** — no year of integrations first

Advisor A is the only interview where all five lined up. **C** and **J** echoed the same reactivation / prioritize-the-book need.

Tradeoff I’m accepting: narrow wedge now; broaden later only if A-like buyers pay.

3. Assumptions along the way

Needs differ by advisor role, purchase cycle, and ultimately **what product they would buy**. One platform that “covers all ten interviews” is a slow enterprise bet, not a founding wedge.

4. Why this product — and what I ignored

Wrong customer — B / D / F

Some interviews weren’t independent wealth advisors at all (CFO reporting, bank/CU ops, tech brokerage). Good problems, different company. Building for them means abandoning the Rowan advisor thesis.

ID	Who	Why not first
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B	Fractional CFO	Different job and market
D	Bank / CU client engagement	Enterprise ops; long procurement
F	Tech broker (not RIA)	Adjacent sales problem, wrong ICP

Right world, wrong shape — E / I

Book transitions and succession can be big money — rare projects, home office often buys or blocks. Consulting-shaped, not a tool someone buys this month and uses every Monday.

ID	Who	Why not first
E	Indie practice acquiring books	High \$, every few years
I	Senior BD / succession	Firm decides; often internal / \$0

Real pain, advisor can't buy — C / G / H

Content, compliance, and firm-wide intel — advisors want it, but marketing or the bank owns budget and approval. Year-long cycle. Not a founding wedge.

ID	Who	Why not first
C	Mutual-co advisor	National marketing owns tools/budget
G	Bank brokerage HNW	Privacy + national approval; advisor can't buy alone
H	Newer bank advisor	Same compliance / approval wall

Say it out loud:

“Across the interviews, needs split by role, purchase cycle, and who holds the budget. Only one path lined up pain, buyer, price, weekly workflow, and ‘buy now’ — independent advisors with a messy dormant book. So I shipped a reactivation desk for that.”

If they push “but X was bigger \$”:

“Bigger check ≠ better first product. I optimized for speed to a paying user, not max theoretical ACV.”

5. Which Rowan themes this product tackles

Mainly these two

- **Surfacing compliant growth opportunities** — core job. Rank dormant prospects, say why to call them, give a talk track, turn a cold book into meetings.
- **Keeping the advisor in control** — never auto-email or auto-dial. Human picks, calls, logs, exports. AI recommends; advisor decides.

Partially / lightly

- **Catching follow-through that would otherwise be missed** — ranked weekly list + outcome log so names don't die in a spreadsheet. Not full meeting → commitment tracking.

Not claiming as the wedge today

- Detecting meaningful changes across clients/prospects (ongoing alerts)
- Moving work safely between people and systems
- Preparing forms, records, and follow-up correctly

Notes / note-takers (honest long-run)

Notes today make reactivation smarter at call time — not a living change monitor. Same ranking engine can later ingest note-takers or CRM feeds as change signals. I started with export + dormant book because A can buy that **now**, without firm-wide monitoring.

6. What I built

Reactivation Desk — export a messy CSV → finishable weekly call list → polished call tips → log outcomes → next week.

Live path

1. Unlock (Sprint / Unlimited or promo)
2. Import a book → AI guesses who you sell to / what you reopen → user corroborates
3. Build a short week (budget you can finish)
4. Open a name → call polish grounded in the file (+ light public context)
5. Wrap → leftovers / next week

Why it's sellable now

Completes one workflow end-to-end with a real input (CSV), no CRM integration, priced as **Sprint (\$499)** or **Unlimited (\$99/mo)** against A's proven reactivation math and failed setter spend.

7. Questions for the panel

1. For Advisor A-like buyers, is **Sprint vs monthly** the right packaging — or should the first SKU be a done-with-you “first week” service?
 2. Where's the line on **public web enrichment** vs compliance comfort for broker-dealer affiliated advisors?
 3. If this works, what's the next wedge you'd want: **deeper call coaching**, **CSA workflow**, or **book-of-business import beyond CSV**?
 4. Who should we put this in front of first — **independents like A**, or **mutual-company advisors like C** with heavier compliance?
 5. What would make this a clear “no” in diligence — accuracy, hallucination risk, or “they won't upload the book”?
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Prototype: <https://reactivation-desk.vercel.app> · Decision memo also at /memo on the same site.